PEW RESEARCH CENTER NEWS INTEREST INDEX
SEPTEMBER 9-12, 2010 OMNIBUS
FINAL TOPLINE
N=1001

ASK ALL:

PEW.1 As I read a list of some stories covered by news organizations this past week, please tell me if you happened to follow each news story very closely, fairly closely, not too closely, or not at all closely. First, **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE ITEMS a THROUGH c FOLLOWED BY RANDOMIZED ITEMS d THROUGH f] [IF NECESSARY** "Did you follow **[ITEM]** very closely, fairly closely, not too closely or not at all closely?"**]**

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a. The debate in Washington over competing Democratic and Republican tax plans					
September 9-12, 2010	16	19	22	42	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
May 8-11, 2009: *The debate in Washington over the federal budget*	22	28	19	31	*
March 27-30, 2009: *Debate over Barack Obama's budget proposal*	28	34	18	19	1
February 27-March 2, 2009: *Barack Obama's budget proposal for next year that raises taxes on wealthy Americans and increases spending on health care, education and other programs*	47	34	9	10	*
February, 2002: *Debate in Congress over G.W. Bush's budget and tax cut plan*	17	31	28	23	1
April, 2001	24	38	20	18	*
February, 2001: *G.W. Bush's tax cut plan*	31	35	19	14	1
b. The major oil leak in the Gulf of Mexico					
September 9-12, 2010	34	34	18	13	1
August 19-22, 2010	41	34	15	9	1
August 12-15, 2010	39	34	17	9	1
August 5-8, 2010	42	36	12	9	1
July 29-August 1, 2010	57	31	10	2	0
July 22-25, 2010	59	29	8	3	*
July 15-18, 2010	50	32	10	7	*
July 8-11, 2010	43	40	10	6	1
July 1-5, 2010	57	29	9	5	*
June 24-27, 2010	56	31	8	5	*
June 17-20, 2010	55	32	6	6	*
June 10-13, 2010	55	31	9	5	*
June 3-6, 2010	57	27	9	6	*
May 27-30, 2010	55	26	11	7	*
May 20-23, 2010: *An oil leak in the Gulf of Mexico threatening the coast of several states*	47	35	11	7	*
May 13-16, 2010	58	29	9	4	*
May 7-10, 2010	46	33	11	10	*
April 30-May 3, 2010: *Oil leaking into the ocean near the Louisiana coast after an off-shore oil rig explosion*	44	35	11	10	*
April 23-26, 2010: *An explosion on an off-shore oil rig near the coast of Louisiana*	21	35	22	23	*
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
April 1-5, 2010: *President Obama's proposal to allow offshore oil and gas drilling*	20	24	21	33	1
July 25-28, 2008: *A major oil spill into the Mississippi River*	14	19	25	41	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
December 4-8, 2002: *The large oil spill polluting the coast of Spain*	15	29	28	27	1
May 4-7, 1989: *The Alaska oil spill*	52	37	7	4	--
c. The ninth anniversary of the September 11th terrorist attacks					
September 9-12, 2010	33	29	19	19	1
September 11-14, 2009: *Eighth anniversary*	31	30	22	17	0
September, 2006: *Upcoming fifth anniversary*	27	35	25	12	1
September, 2002: *Coverage of the upcoming anniversary*	39	35	18	7	1
d. News about this year's congressional elections					
September 9-12, 2010	22	23	21	34	1
September 2-6, 2010	26	24	23	26	1
August 26-29,2010	20	27	23	28	1
August 19-22, 2010	19	23	24	33	1
August 12-15, 2010	20	22	19	38	1
July 29-August 1, 2010	29	34	22	14	*
July 15-18, 2010	17	23	26	33	1
June 10-13, 2010	20	29	24	27	1
May 20-23, 2010	23	25	24	27	*
April 23-26, 2010	20	25	19	35	*
March 5-8, 2010	25	27	21	26	1
January 8-11, 2010	20	24	26	29	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
October 24-27, 2008: *News about candidates for local and statewide elections*	20	35	24	20	1
Early November, 2006: *News about candidates and election campaigns in your state and district*	27	37	18	17	1
Late October, 2006 *(RVs)*	27	45	17	11	*
Early October, 2006	21	38	25	15	1
Early September, 2006	16	32	28	23	1
August, 2006	20	29	28	22	1
June, 2006	18	30	29	21	2
May, 2006	18	28	30	23	1
Early November, 2002 *(RVs)*	27	46	18	9	*
Late October, 2002 *(RVs)*	28	34	24	13	1
Early October, 2002 *(RVs)*	21	46	22	10	1
Early September, 2002	17	29	29	24	1
Late October, 1998 *(RVs)*	26	45	20	9	*
Early October, 1998 *(RVs)*	21	43	24	11	1
Early September, 1998	17	32	28	23	*
Early August, 1998	13	30	28	23	1
June, 1998	9	27	33	30	1
April, 1998[1]	16	33	24	27	*
November, 1994	18	42	25	15	*
Late October, 1994	14	38	31	16	1
Early October, 1994	23	34	23	19	1
September, 1994	19	34	29	18	*
November, 1990	38	34	17	11	*
October, 1990	18	32	28	22	*

[1] In April 1998, September 1994 and October 1990, story was listed as "Candidates and election campaigns in your state." In November 1990, story was listed as "Candidates and elections in your state."

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
e. Controversy over a Florida pastor's plan, later cancelled, to burn copies of the Koran on September 11th[2]					
September 9-12, 2010	33	25	15	25	1
TREND FOR COMPARISON:					
June, 2005: *Newsweek's retraction of a story about flushing the Koran down a toilet as part of prisoner interrogation*	20	29	21	29	1
f. The current situation and events in Afghanistan					
September 9-12, 2010	30	33	20	17	*
July 29-August 1, 2010	34	35	22	9	*
July 15-18, 2010	22	33	23	22	*
July 8-11, 2010	23	32	24	20	1
July 1-5, 2010	29	34	23	14	1
June 17-20, 2010	21	30	27	22	*
May 20-23, 2010	22	33	25	20	*
April 9-12, 2010	21	29	27	22	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
June 24-27, 2010: *General Stanley McChrystal resigning as head of U.S. forces in Afghanistan after being quoted criticizing President Obama and his Afghanistan strategy*	28	31	19	21	1
February 19-22, 2010: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	24	36	21	19	*
January 8-11, 2010: S*uicide bombing that killed seven Americans at a CIA base in Afghanistan*	24	31	27	17	1
December 11-14, 2009: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	35	33	18	13	*
December 4-7, 2009: *President Obama's decision to send more U.S. troops to Afghanistan*	43	33	14	8	1
November 20-23, 2009: *The debate over whether to send more troops to Afghanistan*	29	31	17	22	1
November 13-16, 2009	29	28	20	22	1
November 6-9, 2009: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	22	35	24	18	*
October 30-November 2, 2009	24	32	21	22	*
October 23-26, 2009	32	29	21	18	*
October 16-19, 2009	25	31	20	24	*
October 9-12, 2009	31	31	21	17	0
September 25-28, 2009: *The debate over whether to send more troops to Afghanistan*	27	40	17	16	*
September 18-21, 2009: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	26	33	25	16	*
September 11-14, 2009	25	35	22	18	1
September 3-6, 2009	23	33	23	21	0
August 7-10, 2009	24	32	23	21	1
March 20-23, 2009	24	32	22	22	*
February 20-23, 2009: *The Obama administration's decision to send 17,000 additional U.S. troops to Afghanistan*	27	29	24	19	1

[2] On the first night of the field period (September 9) the item was worded: "Plans by a Florida pastor to burn copies of the Koran on September 11th".

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
January 30-February 2, 2009: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	26	34	24	16	*
January 2-4, 2009	22	33	23	21	1
October 24-27, 2008	28	32	22	17	1
October 10-13, 2008: *The military effort in Afghanistan against Taliban fighters*	19	34	29	18	*
September 12-15, 2008	21	34	25	19	1
August 29-31, 2008	18	27	32	23	*
July 18-21, 2008	27	33	24	16	*
July 11-14, 2008	19	28	29	23	1
July 3-7, 2008	19	28	32	21	*
June 20-23, 2008	20	30	30	20	*
Late July, 2002: *The U.S. military effort in Afghanistan*	41	38	13	7	1
June, 2002	38	32	20	9	1
April, 2002	39	39	13	8	1
Early April, 2002	45	37	12	5	1
February, 2002	47	39	8	5	1
January, 2002	51	35	9	4	1
December, 2001	44	38	12	5	1
Mid-November, 2001	49	36	11	3	1
Early November, 2001	45	36	12	6	1
Mid-October, 2001	51	35	10	3	1

ASK ALL:

PEW.2 Which ONE of the stories I just mentioned have you followed most closely, or is there another story you've been following MORE closely? [**DO NOT READ LIST. ACCEPT ONLY ONE RESPONSE.]**

27	The major oil leak in the Gulf of Mexico
17	Controversy over a Florida pastor's plan, later cancelled, to burn copies of the Koran on September 11th
10	The current situation and events in Afghanistan
9	The ninth anniversary of the September 11th terrorist attacks
8	News about this year's Congressional elections
3	The debate in Washington over competing Democratic and Republican tax plans
13	Some other story **(VOL.)**
13	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**

ASK ALL:

PEW.3 Thinking about recent news coverage of some people and groups, would you say the press has been too easy, too tough or fair in the way it has covered **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE]**?

		Too easy	Too tough	Fair	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a.	Barack Obama				
	September 9-12, 2010	27	23	37	13
	July 15-18, 2010	27	24	39	10
	April 9-12, 2010	29	21	42	8
	October 3-6, 2008	31	7	60	2
	April 25-28, 2008	26	17	52	5
	March 20-24, 2008	23	15	55	7
	February 29-March 3, 2008	28	8	58	6
	February 1-4, 2008	23	8	61	8
b.	Republican leaders in Congress				
	September 9-12, 2010	24	16	40	20
	July 15-18, 2010	22	15	45	18

PEW.3 CONTINUED…

		Too easy	Too tough	Fair	(VOL.) DK/Ref
c.	Democratic leaders in Congress				
	September 9-12, 2010	26	12	43	18
	July 15-18, 2010	27	12	44	17

PEW.4 AND PEW.5 PREVIOUSLY RELEASED

ASK ALL:

PEW.6 Now thinking about the oil spill in the Gulf of Mexico, are you hearing mostly good news, mostly bad news or a mix of good and bad news about the situation in the Gulf of Mexico?

Sep 9-12 2010		Aug 5-8[3] 2010	Jul 22-25 2010	Jul 15-18 2010
17	Mostly good news	25	11	18
19	Mostly bad news **[OR]**	25	28	31
58	A mix of good and bad	47	59	48
5	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**	3	2	3

PEW.7-PEW.11 PREVIOUSLY RELEASED

[3] In August 5-8, this was asked as a list item and was worded: "…and how about the oil spill in the Gulf of Mexico? are you hearing mostly good news, mostly bad news, or a mix of good and bad news about the oil spill in the Gulf of Mexico?"